



Who's who?

The brilliant scientist and mathematician Isaac Newton once said, "If I have seen farther, it was by standing on the shoulders of giants". Newton meant that his own work, like that of all mathematicians, was built on the work of the great mathematicians who lived before him. Here are some of the biggest names in maths, starting in ancient Egypt.

All is number

EUREKA!



AHMOSE
about 1700 BC

The world's first-known mathematician was an Egyptian called Ahmose. In 1700 BC he filled a 6 metre (20 ft) long scroll of papyrus paper with 85 mathematical puzzles and their answers. One showed how to multiply by doubling repeatedly. It was a forerunner of the binary system that makes today's digital age possible. Ahmose was merely the person who copied the scroll – the true authors are lost in the past.

PYTHAGORAS
569–475 BC

The Greek philosopher Pythagoras founded a secretive religion based on maths. He said "All is number", believing maths could explain anything. For instance, he showed that halving the length of a musical string gave a note one octave higher. Pythagoras realized Earth was round and proved the famous theorem about right-angled triangles. He also believed in reincarnation and forbade the eating of beans.

EUCLID
325–265 BC

The Greek mathematician Euclid wrote the most successful maths textbook ever: *The Elements*. It contained 250 years' worth of Greek maths, all explained in simple and logical steps. *The Elements* was used to teach geometry in schools worldwide for more than 2000 years, until recently. Euclid also proved there's an infinite number of prime numbers, and that the square root of 2 is an irrational number.

ARCHIMEDES
287–212 BC

Archimedes is best known for leaping out of his bath and running naked down the street crying "Eureka!" after discovering the principle of hydrostatics. The most brilliant of all Greek mathematicians, he found pi to 3 decimal places, discovered the volume and surface area of a sphere, invented war machines, and explained pulleys and levers. He said, "Give me a lever long enough and a firm place to stand. I'll move the Earth".

